“Bihar is introducing subsidised helicopter tourism services to enable visitors to travel conveniently to Bodh Gaya, Nalanda and the Jungle Safari at Valmiki Nagar”

KEDAR PRASAD GUPTA
Minister of Tourism, Bihar



TSHERING THENDUP BHUTIA
Minister of Commerce & Industries, Tourism & Civil Aviation, Sikkim

“Tourism remains the backbone of Sikkim’s economy. The state has introduced strict environmental measures, including restrictions on plastic water bottles, mandatory garbage bags in tourist vehicles”

INDIA TODAY TOURISM SURVEY & AWARDS 2026

FIRESIDE CHAT

“Goa’s global recall is there, but it has to translate into arrival and spending”

“While digital transformation [app-based cab services] is necessary, the average Goan business owner shouldn’t be adversely affected”



BANDEEP SINGH

ROHAN KHAUNTE
Minister of Tourism, Information Technology, Electronics & Communications and Printing & Stationery, Goa

BEYOND GOA’S SUN AND SAND

Rohan Khaunte began the India Today Tourism Survey and Awards with a clarification. Goa’s “susegad” mentality doesn’t mean a laidback attitude but rather a feeling of contentment. As the state’s tourism minister, he also highlighted the administration’s primary objectives.

Since 2022, when Dr Pramod Sawant’s government took the reins, there has been a significant effort to showcase Goa beyond its beaches. “We are speaking about other verticals and building them too—villages, adventure, wellness, culinary experiences, heritage and tradition,” said Khaunte. Sports tourism is another area being explored. The change in strategy is necessary to keep pace with the evolving preferences of tourists. “A tourist who comes to Goa makes it his second home or wants to come back and explore more,” he noted.

Goa’s lovely yellow Portuguese villas are already etched in the minds of travellers across the globe. But Khaunte wants to add more memorable images to that. Among his initiatives are activating a homestay policy with a special focus on women’s empowerment and promoting rural and spiritual tourism, with 11 temples identified as attractions.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **The Goa administration is actively working towards promoting Goa beyond the sun, sand and sea it’s known for, with churches and temples a focus**
- **Regenerative tourism is a priority, with culture, society, environment and economy as the key pillars of the policy**
- **Tourism policy must factor in the interests of the local community**
- **The PPP (public-private partnership) model policy accounts for both vision and trust**